

## Test Layer 4: Unified Action Point System

Version: 2026-04-25 framework. To be finalised after Layers 1–3 are tested.

**Framework — to be finalised after Layers 1–3 are tested.** Incorporates whichever Layer 1–3 changes were accepted. Sections marked [FROM LAYER X] indicate where those results plug in.

**What we're testing:** Does collapsing two turn phases into a single Action Point pool create better decisions and reduce cognitive overhead?

**Hypothesis:** When moving and casting draw from the same resource (AP), every action involves an opportunity cost trade-off. This creates more “agonising choices” and makes spells feel more central — they compete directly with movement rather than living in a separate phase.

**Watch for:**

- Do turns feel more fluid (one decision space) or more overwhelming (too many options)?
- Do players spread AP across pieces or focus on one?
- Does anyone rush a piece across the board using all 3 AP for movement?
- Are “pure caster” turns (0 movement, 3 skills) viable and interesting?
- Is 3 AP the right number?

### Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

**Draw conditions:**

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

### Components

- **Board:** [FROM LAYER results — likely 10×10, no terrain.]
- **Per player:** [Current piece count — likely 5 Champions + 6 Guards + 1 King unless changed.]
- **Shared:** Skill tokens/cards, Money tokens, Round tracker.

### Setup

[Same as current after Layer 1–3 results.]

### **CHANGED: Turn Structure — Unified Action Points**

**Old system (two phases):**

1. Move Phase: 2 actions
2. Skill Phase: N actions

**New system (unified):**

Each turn you receive **3 Action Points (AP)**. You may spend each AP on one of:

- **Move:** Move one piece (by its speed).
- **Skill:** Activate one equipped skill on a Champion or King (pay Money cost).
- **Attack:** Perform a Move-Attack (move onto enemy tile, deal 1 damage).

You may use 0, 1, 2, or 3 AP. Unused AP are lost — no banking.

**The separate per-phase action budgets are removed.** Each skill activation costs 1 AP + its Money cost. The former Skill Phase progression (was +1 every 10 rounds) is replaced by the flat 3 AP per turn. If the game needs late-game escalation, consider increasing AP to 4 after Round 15 (test separately).

### Piece Freedom — Test All Four Models

| Model    | Rule                                                                                           | Rationale                                                                            |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>A</b> | Each piece can use at most 1 skill per turn. Moving the same piece multiple times is allowed.  | Spreads skill usage. Doesn't prevent movement rushing.                               |
| <b>B</b> | Each piece can receive at most 1 AP per turn.                                                  | Forces spreading across army. Most restrictive — every AP goes to a different piece. |
| <b>C</b> | Uncapped normally. When $\leq 2$ pieces remain, that player's pieces can receive unlimited AP. | Standard play spreads actions. Desperation mode enables comeback.                    |
| <b>D</b> | A single piece can receive at most 2 AP per turn. The 3rd AP must go to a different piece.     | Allows Move + Skill on one piece but prevents full-AP rushing. Moderate.             |

**Recommended test order:** Start with Model D (moderate, intuitive). If too restrictive → test A. If rushing is a problem → test B. Test C as a variant on whichever base model works.

## Combat

*[FROM LAYERS 2–3: Use 3 HP system if accepted. Use simplified Bodyguard if accepted.]*

**Move-Attack:** Spend 1 AP to move your piece onto an enemy-occupied tile. Deal 1 damage. If target removed, occupy tile. If target survives, your piece stops on the tile before.

## Resource Economy

*[FROM LAYER 1 results.]*

## Skill System

**Path:** Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

**Blocking:** The Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

**Range:** The distance in tiles along the Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along the Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along the Path (etc.)

**Default Range = 2.** Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

**Self vs. adjacent:** “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

**Injured Range penalty:** Injured pieces have Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

**Skills that move pieces do not deal damage.** Movement-via-skill (Dash, Swap, Retreat) does not count as a Move-Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

**A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn** if actions are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 action unless noted otherwise.

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## Health & Armor

**All pieces have 2 HP:** Normal → Injured → Removed.

| State   | HP | Effect                                               |
|---------|----|------------------------------------------------------|
| Normal  | 2  | No penalty                                           |
| Injured | 1  | Speed capped at 1. Range -1 (affects Range 2+ only). |
| Removed | 0  | Piece leaves the board permanently.                  |

### Damage:

- 1 damage to Normal → Injured.
- 1 damage to Injured → Removed.
- 2 damage to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

**Armor:** Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 damage, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

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## Progression

### AP per turn:

| Round                          | AP per turn |
|--------------------------------|-------------|
| All rounds                     | 3           |
| After Round 15 (optional test) | 4           |

## Skill Reference

|                                                                                     | Cat.   | Name    | Cost | Effect                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|---------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | Strike | Lance   | 2    | Target within Range-1 takes 1 damage                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|    | Strike | Hook    | 3    | Target takes 1 damage, pulled 1 tile toward caster along the Path                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|    | Strike | Break   | 2    | Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Charge)</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|    | Strike | Steal   | 3    | Target takes 1 damage. Steal 1 Money from opponent.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|    | Strike | Tempest | 4    | Target takes 1 damage. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|    | Shield | Shield  | 2    | Self: gain +1 Armor                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|    | Shield | Heal    | 3    | Remove Injured from one adjacent ally                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|    | Shield | Plate   | 3    | Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|    | Move   | Dash    | 3    | Self: move up to 2 tiles along the Path                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|    | Move   | Blast   | 2    | Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|    | Move   | Shove   | 3    | Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). <b>Range+1.</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|   | Move   | Swap    | 4    | Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Path.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|  | Move   | Retreat | 4    | Self: move along the Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. <b>Range+1.</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|  | Mystic | Focus   | 1    | The next skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> <b>Move skills:</b> the caster chooses, when activating the Move skill, whether the +1 applies to its <b>activation range</b> (how far the skill can target) or its <b>effect range</b> (how far it moves/pushes). Not both. |
|  | Mystic | Charge  | 3    | One Strike skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn deals +1 damage.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## Post-Game Questions

1. Did turns feel more fluid or more overwhelming?
2. How often did you want a 4th AP? How often did you have AP left over?
3. Did you ever rush a single piece across the board? Was it effective or punished?
4. Did "Move + Skill on the same piece" feel like a natural combo?
5. Which piece freedom model did you test? How did it feel?
6. Do you miss the two-phase structure? Or is unified AP better?
7. Should AP increase in later rounds, or is 3 flat the right number?

## Layer 5: Board Size & Piece Count (Placeholder)

Cannot be fully specified until Layer 4 results are in. The AP budget and piece count interact too heavily.

**Direction:** Shrink to 8×8. Reduce pieces (3 Champions + 3 Guards + 1 King is the proposal, but the exact ratio depends on how AP and HP systems interact).

### Key questions for Layer 5:

- Is 8×8 with 14 pieces the right density?
- Is 3:3 Champion:Guard ratio correct? (King makes 4 skill-carriers vs 3 Guards — asymmetric)
- Does starting placement matter significantly on 8×8? Should it become a strategic choice?

- Is no terrain the right call, or does the smaller board need terrain to create interesting zones?

*Will be written as a full rule sheet after Layers 1–4 are resolved.*